

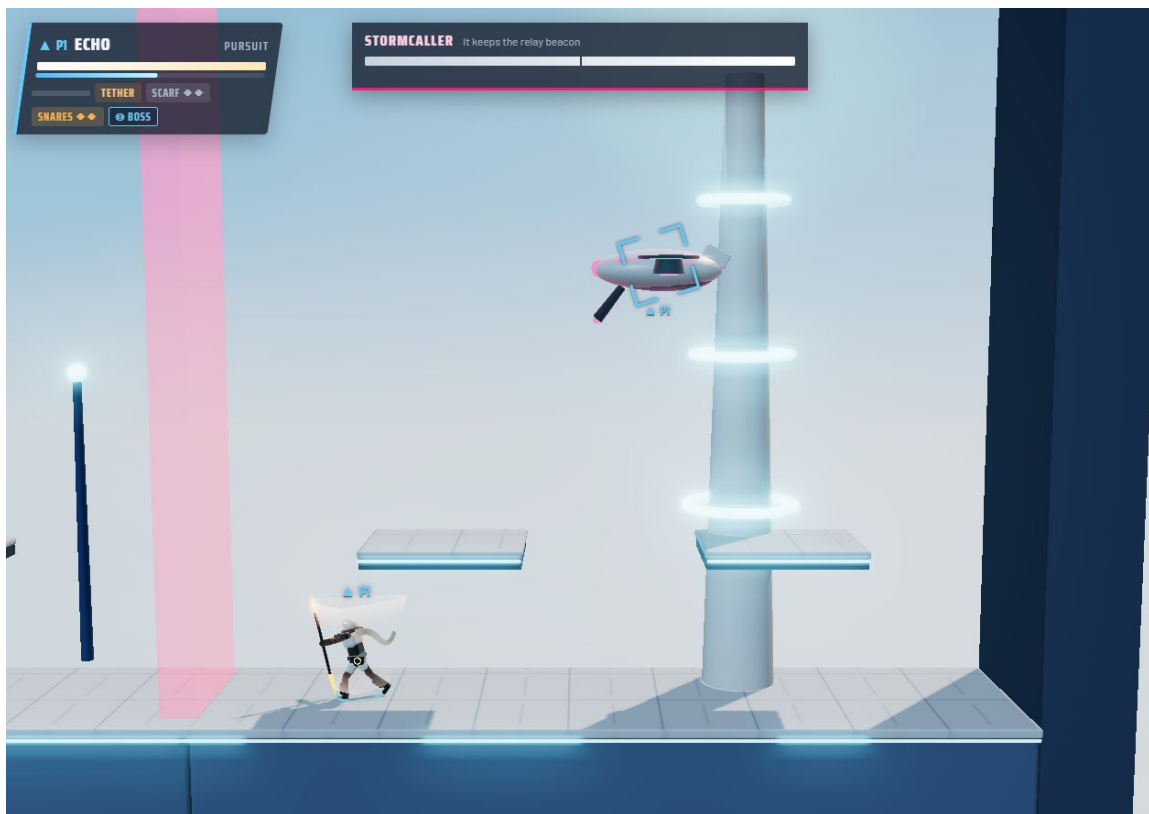
Nova Striker Improvement Proposal

Concept | Graphics | Gameplay
October 2, 2026

The recommended next version

Nova Striker has a promising foundation for a movement-driven cooperative action platformer. Its most valuable next step is one cohesive, polished mission that makes the existing depth easy to understand and satisfying to use.

I would retain the four heroes, responsive movement systems, bright city setting and combat architecture. I would organize the next version around a concrete mission: restore a storm-disabled relay and bring the skyport back to life. This is a proposed creative direction, not established story canon.



Current Version 10 build: Echo facing the Stormcaller. The sky-city setting, character equipment and boss structure offer a useful foundation for the proposed mission.

Concept: give the team a mission with visible consequences. **Graphics:** create a playable animated action style with distinct hero silhouettes and choreographed impacts. **Gameplay:** connect character moves into expressive chains, let the environment react and preserve input intent through combat transitions.

First priorities: reliable buffered inputs during impact pauses, one polished action chain per hero, a small set of interactive level objects and a short mission that brings them together. Target 12-18 minutes for the completed slice, then tune from playtests.

Evaluation of the current build

This is a developed mechanics prototype with an unfinished player-facing experience. The gap between the amount of functionality and the clarity of its presentation is the central issue.

What is worth preserving

The game already has four differentiated kits, four zones, two bosses, local drop-in co-op, revives and team ultimates. Coyote time, buffered jumping, wall movement, double jumps and air dashes support forgiving traversal. Velocity Breaks convert movement into powerful attacks, creating a useful connection between platforming and combat. [R1, R2]

RAM can physically protect teammates and Fix can heal, revive and improve their effectiveness. Bosses include deliberate counterplay such as crashing into solid level geometry and exposed recovery windows. The attack director limits simultaneous enemy commitments. These are substantive design strengths. [R3, R4]

Where the experience needs work

Area	Current assessment	Implication
Concept	The opening explains a prototype and its controls; mission stakes and payoff are slight.	Introduce a goal, a reason to care and an observable consequence.
Graphics	The bright setting is coherent, but rounded primitive models and repeated surfaces read as placeholders.	Build a consistent art target and improve contrast at actual camera distance.
Gameplay	There is extensive depth, including contextual inputs and many charge states.	Teach and stabilize the core actions before adding more systems.
Production	The simulation is separated from rendering and has extensive regression checks.	Preserve this structure and add complete player-experience validation.

Evidence and limits

I inspected the source at commit **0b8bbe61**, opened all four zone entry points, sampled all four characters and both boss entry points through keyboard controls, and reviewed live screenshots and menus. The browser log query returned no warnings or errors in that session. These were short interaction checks, not completed mission playthroughs or multiplayer sessions.

The existing runner completed **220 checks with 0 failures**. Its simulation coverage is useful, but some tests pre-clear encounters, force revives or enable dash invulnerability. Passing them does not demonstrate default-settings balance, controller feel, audio quality or sustained performance on target hardware. [R5]

A clearer concept and player promise

Position Nova Striker as a fast, expressive action game about a specialist crew protecting a city above the clouds. Cooperation and momentum should define its identity.

The proposed premise

A storm has disrupted the city's relay network and left its security machines behaving dangerously. Nova, Echo, RAM and Fix must cross the concourse, climb the spire and restore the relay so transit and evacuation can resume. Show the failure through stalled pods, broken signs and unsafe machinery. Keep the opening brief and playable.

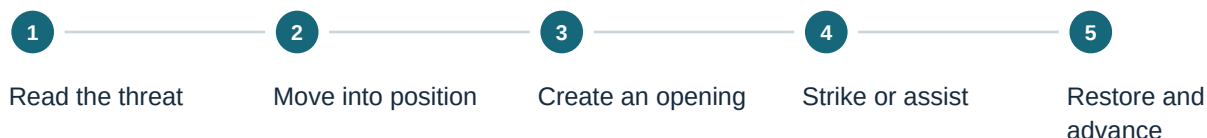
The team should feel capable, warm and lightly competitive. Give each hero a recognizable attitude through short responses to actual events: a shield save, a risky launch, a repair or a revive. Existing rescue barks provide a starting point. Longer biographies can wait until the characters' behavior is memorable. [R6]

Three principles for deciding what to build

Momentum creates opportunities. Traversal should put players in useful combat positions, and successful combat should help them continue moving. Velocity Breaks, launches and dash refunds can express this without adding another meter.

Every hero enables a teammate. A great RAM moment creates safety for someone else; a great Fix moment creates time or opportunity. Nova and Echo should also set up allies through positioning, pressure and enemy control. A full party should never be required to finish the mission.

The city is worth saving. Preserve the daylight, height and civic architecture. Let success restore light, movement and ambient activity. The world should communicate both the problem and the reward.



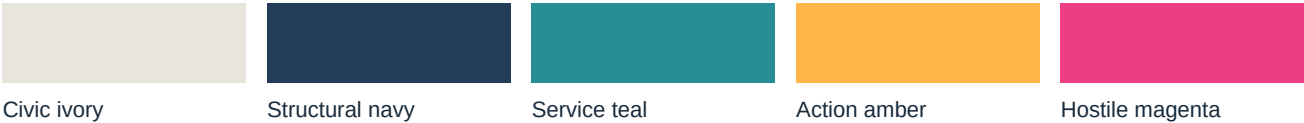
Mission structure and replay

Use compact authored missions with a clear start, escalation and finish. Reward replay with optional routes, personal bests and challenges that recognize clean execution and teamwork. Later unlocks should offer alternate tactics or cosmetics; broad numerical power growth would complicate balancing before the core is established.

The working scope is desktop keyboard and controller play with solo and local co-op. Preserve immediate access to every hero in training. Defer online multiplayer, a large campaign, more heroes and elaborate loot systems until the first mission earns repeated play.

Graphical direction and character identity

Make Nova Striker look like a playable animated science-fiction action series: bold 3D silhouettes, graphic lighting, expressive mechanical motion and controlled bursts of energy against a luminous city.



This proposed palette develops colors already present in the build. Use ivory and navy for architecture, teal for civic systems, amber for selected opportunities and magenta for hostile energy. Pair functional colors with silhouettes, patterns and symbols; player identity must retain its separate shape-and-number cues. [R7]

Hero	Visual identity to strengthen	Animation and effects priority
Nova	Compact angular armor, a prominent bracer and a distinct visor profile.	Clear charge poses, planted releases and directional launch energy.
Echo	Long scarf arc, slim stance and a glaive silhouette visible at distance.	Decisive anticipation, sweeping attack arcs and controlled scarf follow-through.
RAM	Broad rectangular mass, oversized shield and a low center of gravity.	Compression before impact, believable recovery and readable guard facing.
Fix	Asymmetric tools, goggles, articulated backpack and a strong wrench profile.	Quick purposeful gestures, clear gadget placement and identifiable repair pulses.

Build a small production art benchmark

Polish Nova, one basic enemy and a short concourse encounter first. Test two- or three-band lighting, selective outlines and strong contact shadows. Keep distant architecture softer, with roughness differences that distinguish armor, rubber, glass and machinery.

Choose whether to refine the procedural rigs or introduce authored models through a rig adapter. The present animation directly drives a shared joint structure, so asset replacement requires integration. Validate the full move set, weapon sockets and effects attachments on one hero before expanding. [R8]

Give districts different visual functions

The concourse should use transit signs, broad arches and human-scale civic props. The spire should emphasize vertical machinery, exposed conduits and moving weather. The relay should open into strong skyline silhouettes, antenna structures and pulsing power routes. Reuse modular pieces, but vary structure and lighting rather than only changing accent color.

Give every action a distinctive impact

Spectacle should come from a readable sequence of force and consequence. The build already has trails, afterimages, impact frames and character effects; they need a shared direction and more deliberate timing.

Prepare and commit A visible weight shift, weapon pose and sound announce force and direction.	Contact and react Precise contact, a short hold, a target reaction and a material-specific sound confirm success.	Recover or connect Effects clear as the hero settles or follows a valid cancel into the next action.

Four visual signatures

Nova compresses and releases. Draw the bracer toward the centerline while charging, anchor the boots, then extend decisively. Use narrow white-gold pressure lines, a focused contact ring and directional fragments. Animate recoil through the arm and torso without adding unwanted body displacement.

Echo cuts and redirects. Lead with the head and shoulders; let the scarf describe the traveled path while the weapon trail describes the active cut. Tether attachment, tension and release should be separate readable moments. A deflect gets a crisp crossing shape and metallic chime.

RAM stores and transfers weight. Guard locks through the shield, shoulders and rear foot. Kinetic energy builds across structural cells; release uses a dense shock front. A wall slam needs enemy compression, a surface response and a debris fan aligned with the impact.

Fix assemblies and restores. Devices unfold, upgrades change their silhouette and mint repair seams reconnect across armor. Differentiate wrench contact on an enemy from work on a gadget. Jack-Up should visibly compress and release, making support movement satisfying.

Scale punctuation with consequence

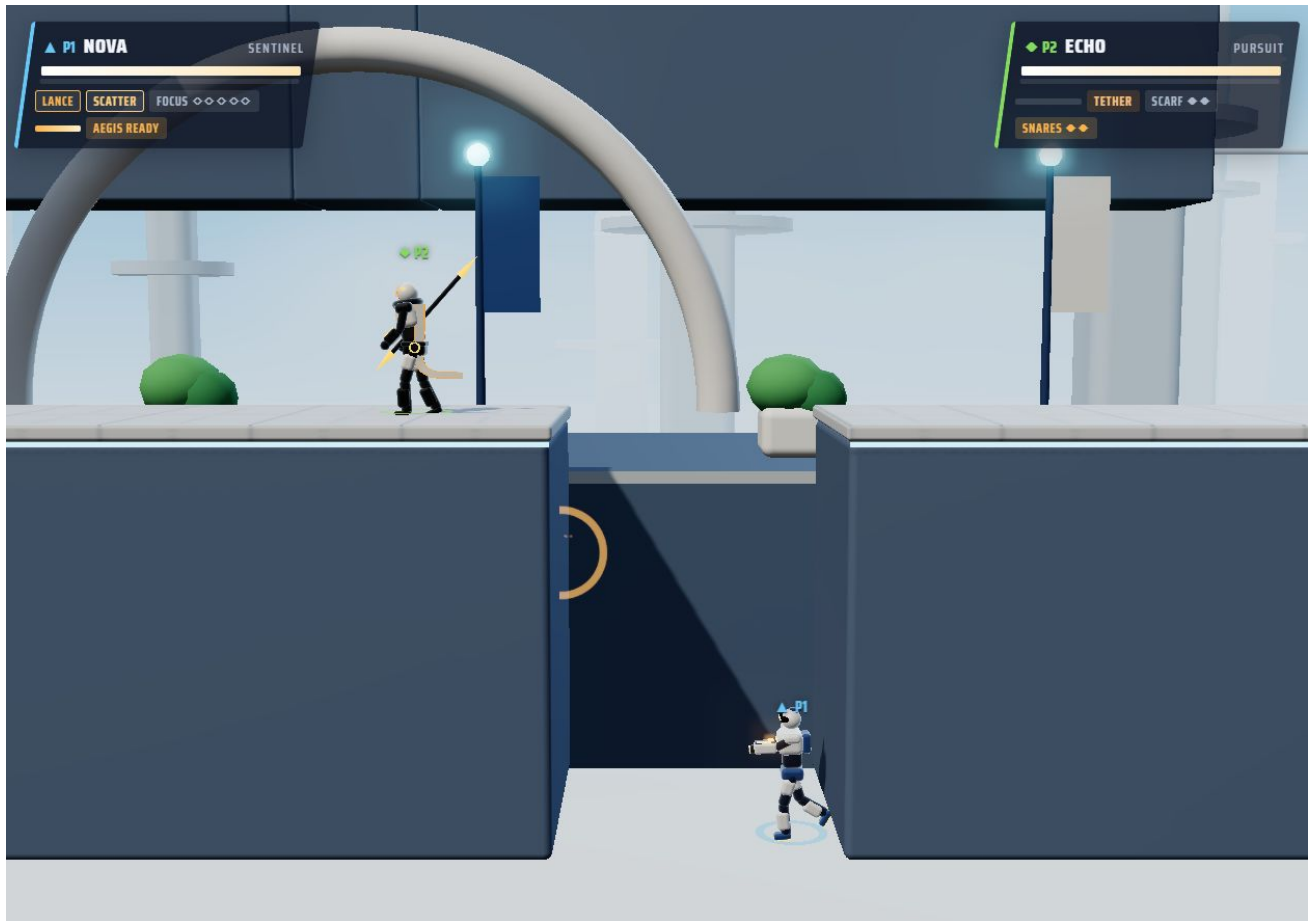
Ordinary contact gets a localized spark, reaction and sound. Armor break receives a stronger pose and small directional camera impulse. A major slam gets one dominant response. A team finisher earns the exceptional composition. In crowded co-op, choose the strongest camera event instead of simply accumulating every shake.

The current screen-wide impact at strength 1 lasts about 0.38 seconds and requests a 0.10-second global pause. Reserve that treatment for rare climaxes; use lighter local punctuation for regular chains. Preserve reduced-flash choices and clear landing visibility. [R9]

Existing ribbon trails, pose-based afterimages, shield cracks and repair arcs provide the raw material. Polish one complete action chain per hero, including target reaction and sound, before increasing particle counts.

Make the action easier to see

Graphical improvement should begin with the relationship between the player, traversable surfaces and danger. More detail is useful only when that relationship stays clear.



Current build: Nova and Echo at different heights in the Movement Gym. Large platform faces and vertical separation make silhouette contrast, landing visibility and shared-camera framing central to the graphical design.

Separate visual layers. Keep distant structures softer and quieter. Give playable ledges a consistent edge treatment, and keep props away from important landing silhouettes. Add local contrast behind characters where bright armor overlaps pale architecture. Review camera occlusion and avoid decorative forms crossing critical attack cues.

Control the effects budget. Damage warnings and player location take priority over hit sparks, ally abilities and decorative particles. Reduce redundant allied effects in four-player scenes. Reserve whole-screen impact treatment for rare decisive events. Bloom, camera shake, impact frames and ultimate letterboxing already exist; the task is to coordinate their intensity. [R9]

Frame the next decision. Show landing areas during traversal and the source of an imminent attack during combat. Keep transitions and boss introductions from hiding the player. Maintain a minimum useful character size when co-op zoom widens; measure this on the target display rather than selecting an arbitrary zoom value.

Gameplay depth with predictable controls

Keep the rich move set, but make each action legible and intentional. The first few minutes should teach a usable combat loop before exposing every attachment and exception.

Teach one core loop per hero

Nova: move, create distance, charge and release. **Echo:** pursue, deflect and reposition. **RAM:** face danger, absorb pressure and create a breach. **Fix:** place support, repair or boost, then rejoin the fight. Every hero still needs a satisfying basic attack and a solo answer to common threats.

Start a newcomer with movement, primary attack, defense and one signature ability. Unlock explanation of secondary options through optional practice prompts, rather than withholding the actual kit from experienced players. Keep the training room available for experimenting with advanced charges and cancels.

Current rule to review	Proposed treatment
Nova's melee/secondary input changes action by proximity.	Offer explicit melee and secondary intent, with contextual assistance optional. Preview which action will happen.
Fix's melee can toss a power-up when no enemy or gadget is close.	Give utility use an explicit input or modifier. Avoid accidental Scrap spending when the player intended a swing.
Echo's ranged input changes between a snare and rifle based on hold duration.	Strengthen the existing rifle-raise and Scope cues before release. Offer separate bindings or a toggle option.
Standing dash can charge; directional dash fires immediately.	Teach this distinction in a safe challenge and clearly indicate the charge state.

These rules are verified in the implementation; their usability cost is a design hypothesis to test with new players. Preserve quick access and controller comfort when evaluating alternatives. [R10]

Make movement the signature mechanic

Build a short sequence that teaches jump, dash and a Velocity Break against a clearly staged target. Show a brief movement-to-hit confirmation and an optional practice indicator for an available cancel. Keep the existing distinction between a rewarded hit and the commitment of a missed attack. [R2]

Use consistent defensive terms. The current standard, heavy and unblockable categories have class exceptions: Nova's Aegis and RAM's guard can stop attacks that the label may imply are universally unblockable. Describe the required response, such as parry, brace or evade, and explicitly teach shield exceptions. [R11]

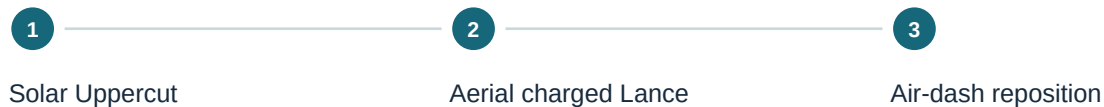
Moveset improvements for Nova and Echo

Give each hero a recognizable rhythm and meaningful follow-up choices. The proposed additions below connect existing abilities rather than expanding every character in every direction.

Nova as mobile precision artillery

Keep: charged attachments, secondary weapons, perfect releases, rocket jumps, skate movement, hover, Solar Uppercut, perfect dodge and Aegis. His defining choice is when to stay mobile and when to commit to a precise release.

Change: separate melee and secondary intent, and offer a preferred two-weapon quick-swap pair alongside the full loadout. Refine the transition from skate movement into a confirmed strike and back into aiming. Retain an intentional precision stop; test a carry-through option that preserves limited momentum on success.



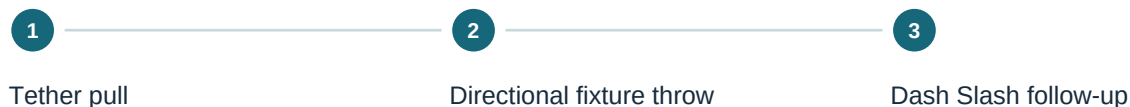
This showcase uses existing moves. The work is to make the charge feedback, input windows and transition poses support the sequence reliably. A proposed power coupler gives charged fire a level interaction: energize a marked mechanism to open an optional angle or route.

Guardrails: no automatic drift off ledges, no blanket removal of recoil or commitment, and no requirement to cycle all weapons mid-combo. Nova should feel precise at ordinary speed before advanced chains demand rapid selection.

Echo as an aerial duelist and manipulator

Keep: blade and glaive chains, rising and wall attacks, deflection, snares, rifle, scarf tether and pogo bounce. His rhythm should be approach, exact contact and repositioning.

Add selectively: a directional release for a tethered light enemy: forward throw, upward setup or downward slam. Offer a directional air-chain ender so the player chooses where the encounter continues. Use the existing Resolve system and appropriate costs instead of adding another meter.



The throw is a proposed extension; tether pull and Dash Slash already exist. Teach the existing pull-to-Rising-Glaive-to-Spin-Slash chain first. Mark a small set of environmental tether anchors and keep their movement on the shared gameplay path.

Guardrails: limit repeated airborne control, preserve boss resistance and show tether tension before release. A clear opposite-direction input should win over unwanted target magnetism. [R2, R10]

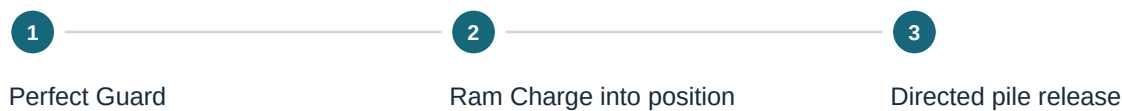
Moveset improvements for RAM and Fix

Heavy and support characters need active, expressive combat loops. Their satisfaction should come from controlling situations and creating visible opportunities for the whole team.

RAM as a shaper of the battlefield

Keep: Perfect Guard, stored Kinetic Release, enemy-carrying charge, wall splats, heavy pickup, seismic attacks, Bulwark Wall, Guardian Link and Provoke. These already communicate a physical tank fantasy.

Add selectively: let a charge end deliberately. Melee sends the carried group forward; up plus melee releases it upward. A successful wall splat opens a short, clearly indicated guard or cannon cancel. His weight should come from startup and commitment, while the response after a confirmed collision stays dependable.



The directed release is new. Guard into Kinetic Release into a charge wall-splat is an existing sequence to polish immediately. Mark optional breach panels and solid slam surfaces so the player can plan a route through the fight.

Guardrails: keep missed charges punishable, make boss and rooted-enemy resistance clear, and avoid permanently juggling large groups. Low-frequency sound, compression and surface response should provide weight without prolonged global pauses.

Fix as an active combat engineer

Keep: Hot Rivets, wrench combos and gadget upgrades, Torque Slam, Jack-Up, the Patch Beam, supplies and the three gadgets. Give players clear opportunities to alternate direct combat with engineering.

Add selectively: a wrench hit can trigger an attached Hot Rivet early. Add deliberate gadget relocation that preserves its upgrade but does not reset health or lifetime for free. Separate supply tossing from proximity-selected melee so a missed swing cannot unexpectedly spend Scrap.



Early detonation is new; Hot Rivet and Jack-Up already exist. Relocation lets her prepare a fight and move with the party instead of repeatedly abandoning upgraded equipment. Show a gadget becoming stronger through physical changes as well as level lights.

Guardrails: consume each rivet once, control detonation chains and prevent relocation from creating unlimited sustain. Give support actions strong feedback without making Fix mandatory. [R3, R10]

Make combat transitions dependable

Fluidity comes from preserving intent, controlling momentum and communicating when an action can connect. Faster animations alone would not resolve the most important issues.

Preserve input through impact pauses

A targeted simulation reproduced lost jump and dodge inputs during Nova's nine-tick Velocity Break hitstop. A press on frozen tick 1 expires before action resumes; the same press on tick 9 executes on tick 10. The world and a teammate continue moving, so this is local hitstop. Preserve a valid press until an eligible action tick, consume it once and discard invalid requests.

Define a consistent cancel policy

Hit-confirm cancels, later whiff cancels, dash refunds and action buffers already exist. Build a small transition specification for every move: startup commitment, active contact, confirmed-hit cancel, whiff recovery and defensive override. Make a fresh defensive press take priority over an older queued combo when the move permits it; do not make every action universally cancellable.

Moment	Desired behavior	What to verify
During local hitstop	Queue intent without losing it to frozen action time.	Exactly one action on the first legal tick.
After a confirmed hit	Allow the advertised movement or defensive follow-up.	No hidden extra recovery; clear transition pose.
After a miss	Retain a readable commitment window.	Defense does not erase every mistake.
During assisted approach	Respect deliberate movement away from the target.	No unintended lunge over an edge.

Make contact crisp without repeatedly stalling play

Current attacker hitstop varies by attack, including three ticks for ordinary melee and five, seven or nine for Velocity Breaks. Give intermediate multi-hit contacts lighter treatment; reserve the strongest pause for a finisher, armor break or wall collision. Separate attacker-local emphasis from global spectacle in co-op.

Keep motion and camera working together

Tune assisted lunges, momentum retention and direction changes as a unit. Add bounded horizontal look-ahead based on motion and attack direction, while retaining the existing rocket-apex and boss framing. Ensure landing zones stay visible and a reversal does not whip the camera. Test at both ordinary and mastery speeds.

Verified with work/evaluation/hitstop-buffer-repro.mjs using production hitEnemy and World.step; the harness arranges the contact state directly. Source: player.js lines 116-130, 477 and 776-802; config.js lines 15-18; combat.js lines 113-118. Camera: world.js lines 1913-1937. [R2, R14]

Make levels respond to the move set

Start with a small, consistent set of interactive objects. Every one should create a combat or traversal choice, with a recognizable appearance and a useful solo solution.

The build already supports wall movement, terrain-assisted rocket jumps, bouncing grenades, Prism ricochets, RAM wall splats, chargers colliding with solid cover and Fix spring pads. Develop these physical relationships before adding broad destruction or arbitrary grappling.

Proposed object	Action and response	Rule that keeps it fair
Breach panel	A heavy impact opens a route; lighter attacks break it more slowly. RAM excels at the shortcut.	Distinct seams and damage states; an ordinary path remains available.
Power fixture	Shooting or striking energizes it; a thrown enemy can trigger a brief stun nearby.	Charge state is visible; limited activation cadence prevents repeated stun locks.
Tether anchor	Echo attaches, tensions and releases along a deliberate traversal arc.	One consistent anchor shape; all destinations have a standard route.
Repair junction	Fix temporarily restores a lift, redirects a hazard or activates a support machine.	A universal basic interaction works; Fix improves speed or usefulness.
Launch surface	An authored pad extends existing spring movement and creates an alternate combat approach.	Clear launch direction and landing area; no class-required jump.

One encounter that demonstrates the system

A relay service bay contains a marked barrier, an elevated firing lane and a disabled lift. RAM can breach the barrier; Echo can redirect a light enemy into a power fixture; Nova can use the exposed ricochet lane; Fix can restore the lift and reposition a sentry. These are advantageous choices, not a mandatory four-player script.

Solo players can use ordinary attacks to open the panel, energize the fixture with a weapon and reach the same destination by a longer route. Limit the first prototype to the panel and fixture, then add the other objects only if they improve decisions rather than interrupt the action with chores.

Make interaction rules reliable

Differentiate solid collision geometry, decorative props and interactive objects. Restore object state on checkpoint retry, handle simultaneous hits once, and apply deliberate rules for friendly hazards, enemy use and multiplayer activation. Use authored responses first; a full physics-destruction system would add cost without proving this design.

Current foundations: player.js line 222; world.js lines 167, 597, 1124 and 1484; combat.js line 384; level.js line 59. Environmental tether anchors and the new object vocabulary are proposed extensions, not existing features.

One mission with a deliberate rhythm

Reshape the existing route into a mission called Restore the Skyline Relay. The proposed 12-18 minute target is a pacing hypothesis to test, not a measurement of the current build.

Beat	Player experience	Design purpose
Concourse arrival	A transit fault establishes the objective. A safe crossing teaches jump and dash.	Explain the mission through action; begin with low pressure.
First breach	Introduce one clear enemy response, then a shielded foe with a flank route.	Teach movement-to-attack and defense before combining threats.
Lockwarden	A shortened encounter emphasizes baiting a charge into marked solid geometry and exploiting recovery.	Check the lesson with a recognizable mid-mission obstacle.
Spire ascent	A safe main path branches into an optional faster route using existing movement abilities.	Provide a breather, height and a chance to express mastery.
Relay restoration	Activate two nearby systems amid controlled enemy pressure. Either may be completed first.	Create a positional choice and opportunities to cover an ally.
Stormcaller and payoff	A final fight reuses familiar warnings and recovery windows. Restoring the relay restarts transit.	Test learned skills, deliver spectacle and show a consequence.

Reuse the existing route, checkpoints and encounter systems. If scope must shrink, keep Lockwarden in training and use Stormcaller as the slice's only boss. [R1, R12]

Give rooms a decision

Replace some kill-all gates with choices about position and timing. In a mortar encounter, a player might reach elevated artillery first, or bait a charger into a marked solid slam surface and punish its recovery. At the relay, teammates can cover an activation or clear a safer route. Keep both objectives close enough for a shared screen, and allow solo players to complete them sequentially.

Avoid a mandatory class lock: a shortcut may favor Echo, RAM or Fix, but the main route must remain viable for any hero. Place a checkpoint before a demanding new lesson and before the final fight. Keep return-to-play time short enough that failure invites another attempt.

Reward more than speed or damage

Finish with mission completion, optional route discoveries, personal bests and team contributions such as saves or useful assists. Offer replay, character selection and training immediately. Present achievements in context rather than a single damage ranking that undervalues protection and support.

Cooperation and combat balance

The characters already support meaningful cooperation. The next task is to make those interactions visible, fair and useful at every party size.

Design opportunities for existing synergies

Stage a brief projectile lane where RAM can shelter a charging Nova, followed by a route where Echo reaches an exposed threat while Fix supports the team. Use Fix's spring pad and repair tools as optional opportunities. Make a successful shield save, boosted release or assisted recovery visible through a restrained cue and a short character response.

Keep class roles flexible. Solo RAM needs encounters he can complete with his mobility, while solo Fix needs offensive satisfaction alongside self-support. Do not require healing, tanking or a full four-character party for ordinary progression. Test duplicate-character parties if the selection system continues to permit them.

Scale pressure before health

Current difficulty adjusts incoming damage and the enemy attack allowance; boss health adds 60 percent of base health for each additional player. Those are useful first-pass controls, but support boosts and coordinated attacks change effective team power. Tune enemy composition, approach directions, attack cadence and recovery windows before relying on larger health pools. [R13]

Measure boss duration and damage during each exposed window for solo, duo and four-player teams. Track enemy idle time and overlapping threats. A longer fight should contain more meaningful decisions, rather than repeating the same solved pattern.

Make boss counterplay unmistakable

Lockwarden should visibly prepare its charge, advertise marked solid slam surfaces and show a clear armor-break or stagger state. Stormcaller should distinguish its attack lanes, protected flight and vulnerable crash window through pose, movement and sound. The mechanics exist; strengthen the causal chain from player action to opening to payoff. [R4]

Support the shared camera

The current co-op logic limits spread and recalls lagging players after 90 simulation ticks. Add an early, unobtrusive separation warning and test a deliberate regroup input. Preserve forgiving recovery and ensure regrouping never places a player into immediate danger. Check vertical separation, high-speed movement and revival at the camera edge. [R14]

Prototype split-screen only if measured shared-camera failures remain after framing and route changes. It would add rendering and interface cost, so it should solve a demonstrated problem. Local co-op playtests with real controllers are required before judging the camera, haptics or team ultimates successful.

Onboarding interface and audio

The menus should help players begin an adventure and understand their current choices. The current reference material remains useful, but it should support play rather than carry the entire teaching burden.

Replace the prototype front door

Use a title scene with Start Mission, Training and Settings, followed by a clear join and character-selection step. Show the active device's prompts and a one-sentence role description. Move version notes and experimental kit variants into a developer view. The current start screen and pause menu expose several internal test decisions. [R15]

In the mission, display one immediate objective and one relevant teaching prompt. Dismiss a prompt when the player demonstrates the action, with a way to replay the lesson. Keep the full controls reference available and let experienced players skip instruction.

Simplify the first read of the HUD

Prioritize health, the hero's main resource, the selected action and imminent danger. Show secondary cooldowns when changing or relevant. Use stable icons with short labels instead of a growing row of equally prominent text chips. Preserve the existing numbered and shaped player markers; give off-screen allies a clear direction and state.

Build on the accessibility already present

The build already offers aim assistance, automatic lock-on, difficulty selection, shake and impact-frame toggles, audio levels and some reduced-motion styling. Add action remapping, hold/toggle alternatives, an optional dedicated controller ultimate binding, retaining the existing keyboard binding, scalable HUD text and separate flash/effects intensity. Essential attack cues should combine shape or pattern with sound and optional haptics. [R7, R9, R15, A1, A2]

Validate these choices with players who use them. Color filters and automated checks help find issues but do not replace player testing. No accessibility certification or broad coverage is claimed by this proposal.

Give sound a clear hierarchy

Retain the event-driven audio and adaptive exploration/combat/intensity music structure. Author a small sound set first: incoming-danger cues, successful defense, armor break, each hero's signature action and mission restoration. Keep threat cues audible over allied attacks and ultimate effects. [R16]

Develop a concise musical motif for the crew and an altered version for the damaged relay. When the city restarts, resolve that motif and change the ambient sound. Review the mix on speakers and headphones; the present assessment does not establish the quality of the synthesized audio by listening.

A practical implementation sequence

I would improve the current architecture in stages. There is enough existing functionality to build the proposed mission without an engine migration or a wholesale rewrite.

Stage	Deliverable and likely effort	Condition for moving forward
1 Core feel	Medium: hitstop-input fix, cancel policy, one clear action chain per hero, control intent and teaching beats.	Inputs survive contact pauses; new players deliberately perform core actions.
2 Compose	Large: bounded moveset extensions, two interactive objects, a complete mission, checkpoints and results.	Every hero can finish under default settings; solo and party routes stay viable.
3 Establish art	Large: one hero, one enemy family and one scene at the target visual/audio quality, then apply it to the mission.	Readability survives the farthest camera, crowded effects and target hardware.
4 Validate	Medium to large: co-op tuning, accessibility checks, performance work and repeat-play testing.	The mission meets agreed experience and technical targets before expansion.

Effort labels are relative judgments, not calendar estimates. Scheduling depends on art, animation, design and engineering capacity. Begin art exploration alongside Stage 1; validate camera and encounter requirements before producing the full asset library.

The first implementation batch

Begin with the hitstop-input fix and the core transition policy. Polish one existing action chain per hero, then prototype one bounded extension per kit and two interactive objects. Build the teaching encounters and graphical benchmark around those chains, with local metrics for missed intent and combat pacing.

Keep useful engineering foundations

Preserve the fixed-step simulation and event boundary used by rendering, sound, haptics and UI. As work proceeds, extract character-specific behavior and encounter data from the larger modules where that directly supports an edited feature. Add repeatable end-to-end scenarios, including default-settings runs, rather than refactoring unrelated code.

Add browser smoke and visual checks, profile crowded fights, and verify the source and standalone builds stay equivalent. For distribution, package dependencies and fonts locally or provide explicit loading failure feedback; the current source and standalone builds depend on public CDNs. [R1]

Defer new characters, additional weapon families, online networking, procedural campaigns and deep progression. Revisit them after the polished mission demonstrates a clear identity and repeatable fun.

How to judge the next version

Use a small set of observable outcomes. The targets below are proposed acceptance criteria, not results achieved by the current prototype.

Question	Proposed test	Provisional success target
Is the purpose clear?	Give 5-8 unfamiliar players the build without coaching; ask their objective after one minute.	At least 80 percent describe the goal accurately.
Does combat preserve intent?	Reproduce inputs during hitstop and test confirmed-hit, miss and defense transitions.	No lost or duplicate queued actions; clear legal cancel windows.
Is the mission viable?	Complete normal-settings runs with each hero, then representative two- and four-player parties.	No softlocks, class-required route or unavoidable camera damage.
Are threats readable?	Review crowded encounters and ask players to identify the source and response after a hit.	No recurring critical cue hidden by scenery or ally effects.
Does cooperation matter?	Observe sheltering, boosts, recovery and combined attacks; ask what helped the team.	Players can identify a useful teammate contribution beyond damage.
Does it run well?	Profile the mission on an agreed minimum PC at 1080p, including four-player effects.	Aim for a stable 60 fps; report frame-time percentiles and spikes.
Does it invite replay?	Offer a second run after completion, then ask what the player would try differently.	Use replay choice and reasons as directional evidence, not market proof.

What to record

Capture completion time, deaths and damage sources, checkpoint retries, ability use, missed or duplicated inputs, accidental utility activations, support actions, boss vulnerability damage and camera recalls. Compare solo, duo and four-player sessions before changing damage or health values.

Risks and the corresponding decisions

Too much scope: prove one mission and one art benchmark first. **Loss of depth while simplifying:** simplify presentation and input intent while retaining advanced options in training. **Support roles becoming obligatory:** complete the main route with every solo hero. **Visual upgrades reducing performance:** profile the benchmark before producing the full asset set.

The first small playtest is diagnostic. Iterate confusing sections and repeat it; a handful of players cannot establish commercial demand.

Evidence and source references

Repository evidence is pinned to the reviewed commit. Printed source paths are relative to fresh-start-prototype/. Screenshots show the current build; mission designs, move changes and acceptance criteria are proposals.

R1 Prototype scope, roster, zones, architecture and CDN requirements. [README.md:3](#)

R2 Velocity Breaks and movement; hit-confirm cancellation. [game/js/player.js:78](#)

R3 Co-op ability implementations; enemy attack director. [game/js/player.js:1253](#)

R4 Boss attacks, counterplay and recovery states. [game/js/bosses.js:13](#)

R5 Test runner; also inspect the validation caveats below. [tests/run-all.mjs:1](#)

R6 Team banter and rescue responses. [game/js/world.js:18](#)

R7 Player shapes, colors and default settings. [game/js/config.js:547](#)

R8 Procedural character construction and silhouettes. [game/js/rigs.js:1](#)

R9 Impact frames and their timing. [game/js/render.js:393](#)

R10 Context-dependent attack inputs. [game/js/player.js:352](#)

R11 Aegis and guard defensive exceptions. [game/js/combat.js:177](#)

R12 Zones, checkpoints, encounters and route endpoint. [game/js/level.js:81](#)

R13 Difficulty tuning; also boss scaling at bosses.js line 334. [game/js/config.js:599](#)

R14 Co-op spread limits and recall. [game/js/world.js:1938](#)

R15 Prototype entry, settings and controls presentation. [game/js/ui.js:98](#)

R16 Adaptive synthesized score. [game/js/music.js:1](#)

Additional evidence: player.js lines 799, 937 and 1399 cover cancels, Echo's hold behavior and Fix's utility input. world.js lines 2080 and 2095 cover route completion and the attack director. anim.js lines 359-391 cover character idle behavior and landing treatment. render.js lines 118-218 cover environment and props.

Test interpretation: tests/skyline-test.mjs lines 30-50 pre-clear encounters and test traversal with Nova and Echo; tests/sim-test.mjs lines 44-65 force revival; tests/boss-test.mjs line 7 enables dash invulnerability. The default setting is false in config.js line 556.

A1. [Microsoft Xbox Accessibility Guideline 103](#) supports communicating critical cues through multiple channels and avoiding color-only information. Consulted October 2, 2026.

A2. [Microsoft Xbox Accessibility Guideline 107](#) informs input remapping and alternatives to demanding input patterns. Consulted October 2, 2026.

Reviewed repository: moderngentlemen-sudo/nova-striker-astra. Full commit: 0b8bbe61b1bb10af256002ddb6482471d88d7a05. Evaluation and proposal prepared for Jason. No gameplay implementation changes are included in this proposal.